The Care Leaders
Learning

Keynote workbook and resource

Living a Careless Life

Understanding the lived experiences of children in care

Luke Rodgers BEM



How to use this resource

Part workbook, part reference. Use it in the keynote, then keep it close: in your bag, in supervision, at your support group. Come back to it whenever a young person puzzles you.

In the room

Do these during the keynote. They take a few minutes each.

On your own

Do these at home or at your desk, in the weeks after.

With your team

Use these in supervision, a team meeting or a support group.

How every activity works

Why. What it is for, in one line.

What good looks like. A worked example. Read it first.

Your turn. Space to write about your young person.

Done when. How you know you have finished.

Back to practice. One thing you will do, and when.

Learn pages. Theory to read and refer back to.

Choose your young person

Think of one young person you are trying to support right now and carry them through this resource. Give them a made-up name and leave out anything that could identify them.



Made-up name _____ **Age** _____

How I know them, and why I chose them

_____

_____

Look after yourself. Some of this may bring up your own experiences. Take a break when you need one, and take anything heavy to supervision or someone you trust.

What's inside

Four parts. Story to notice, Theory to understand, Action to practise, and Keep for the tools you will come back to.



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Start here: the lighter

A composite story. It draws on real experiences but is not one person. Read it, then answer honestly.



In the room

Jay, 14

It's period four on a Wednesday and Jay's science class is lighting Bunsen burners for the first time. Jay has been in his foster home for six weeks and this is his third school in two years. He is quiet in lessons and mostly keeps his head down.

The gas taps are on and nobody can find the striker. While the rest of the group waits, Jay takes a lighter out of his blazer pocket and lights their burner. A couple of the others laugh.

Mr Hughes sees it from across the room. He goes red and points at the door. "Out. Now."

Jay stands in the corridor for ten minutes. When Mr Hughes comes out he is still angry. "Give me that. Where on earth did you get a lighter from?"

Jay looks at the floor. "It's my mum's," he says. Then, quietly, "I don't live with her any more. I'm in care."

Mr Hughes stops. Nobody had told him. His face changes completely. He hands the lighter back and says, "Just keep it in your bag, OK?"

The lighter wasn't his mum's. Jay got it from a friend.



You are Mr Hughes. Jay has just told you he is in care. What do you say next?

What happened to your anger when you read his answer?

What would you do with the lighter?

Keep your answers. We come back to Jay on page 24.

1

Story

Meet Sam. First you will read what is written about Sam. Then you will read Sam's story.



In this part

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Sam's story, and the same two scores	In the room	Page 8

Where you are

Story
You are here

Theory

Action

Keep

We inherit words

What words do we use to describe children with a social worker? Somewhere, without meaning to, we store them. Then they start to do our thinking for us.



In the room

Challenging | High risk | Vulnerable | LAC and CIN | Damaged

What the word quietly becomes

Challenging	"They are going to display challenging behaviour."
High risk	"They are dangerous to be around."
Vulnerable	"They cannot look after themselves."
LAC and CIN	"They are lacking and in need."
Damaged	"They are broken."

They are broken » They are unfixable » I can't help

Which words have you heard, or used, this month?

Meet Sam, 16. Everyone writes about Sam.



A profile is a statutory document. It can go by different names. It often arrives long before the young person does.

In the room

Sam's profile

Is at high risk of absconding.

Persistent young offender with offences including burglary and affray.

Known to deal and has been caught with drugs at school.

Has stolen previous foster carer's car in the night.

Low attendance at school and is disengaged with other pupils.

Has issues with attachment.

Isolates themselves in their room. We are seeking psychological assessments as we think it links to early childhood trauma.

Disruptive behaviour when confronted with authority, and their "outbursts" are hard to control.

Struggles to follow simple house rules when living in a foster placement.

Hard to build a rapport as can be guarded and "closed".

Pause. On your own, score these from 1 (low) to 10 (high).

How confident would you be offering Sam a place in your school, home or service? **/10**

How concerned would you be about Sam? **/10**

Hold these answers.

Sam's profile, and Sam's story

The same events, read twice. On the left is what was written.
On the right is what was actually happening.



What was written	What was happening
High risk of absconding	Was late home.
Burglary and affray	Took their own things from their parents' house without asking. Sam was attacked for it.
Known to deal, caught with drugs	Smoked some weed with friends at school.
Stole a foster carer's car	Frightened and lonely, drove to see their mum. This happened once.
Low attendance, disengaged	Always being moved school. Just wants friends.
Issues with attachment	Struggles to feel safe with people.
Isolates in their room	When reminded of an abusive family, goes to their room and is often found crying.
"Outbursts" with authority	Lived where abuse was normal. Gets scared when they hear shouting.
Struggles with house rules	Has lived in so many places the rules keep changing. Hard to keep up.
Guarded and "closed"	**Sam just wants to be loved.**

Score again. Confident to offer Sam a place? Concerned about Sam? Compare with page 7.

/10 /10

"I can't help" becomes "I want to help."

What changes when the language changes

Did your scores move? What moved them?

2

Theory

Why the words stick, what Sam's brain learned to expect, and how two systems clash.



In this part

Five biases hiding in the file	Learn	Page 11
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Attachment, the brain and survival responses	Learn	Page 13
Two timetables and your planner	On your own	Page 16

Where you are

Story	**Theory** You are here	Action	Keep

Five biases hiding in the file

Unconscious bias is the associations we hold, outside our conscious awareness and control. It is an umbrella term. These five showed up in Sam's profile, and they show up in every file.



Learn

	Bias	What it does	Ask yourself
1	**Age**	Treating who they were at one age as who they are now.	**What has changed since this was written?**
2	**Gender**	Boys read as risky, girls as vulnerable.	**Would I write it the same way about a girl, or a boy?**
3	**Anchor**	The first thing you read frames everything after it.	**Did I meet them before I read about them?**
4	**Horns effect**	One bad trait colours the whole picture.	**What are they good at?**
5	**Confirmation**	New information gets fitted to the old story.	**What would prove me wrong?**

The language we use creates three problems

Redundancy
We don't feel we have the skills to help.

Judgement
We wrongly judge young people.

Rejection
Young people are rejected.

> **"Changing words won't change worlds. We need to know our young people."**
>
> Luke Rodgers BEM, Lived Experience Leader



Rewrite a profile

A profile often arrives before the young person does. Honest about what they need, and just as clear about who they are.



On your own | With your team

Why. So the first thing anyone reads about a young person makes them want to say yes.

Written about Sam	What good looks like
Persistent young offender. Known to deal. Has stolen previous foster carer's car. Disruptive when confronted with authority. Hard to build a rapport.	Sam is 16 and loyal to their friends. Sam has moved home and school many times and wants to stay put. Sam gets scared when adults shout, and settles with time alone, then a calm adult who checks in. Once, frightened and lonely, Sam drove to see their mum. Sam wants friends, and to be loved.

Your turn: your young person, in their best light and honestly

Who they are

What they are good at, or proud of

What has happened to them

What helps on a hard day

1. Would they recognise themselves?
2. Does it say what helps, not only what goes wrong?
3. Would you be happy for them to read it at 18?

Done when. Every box is filled and the three checks are a yes.

Back to practice. Next time you write about them, or speak about them in a meeting, start with who they are.

What Sam learned before 10

Mum was non-nurturing. Dad was neglectful and absent. Step-dad was strict and abusive. A quick look at child development shows what that taught Sam.



0 to 4 years

Developing: relationships with parents · first attachment style · wanting their attention · trust · the roles of mum and dad

"My parents don't love me. They are always fighting and when I cry no one comforts me."

"I can't trust my parents. They don't keep me safe."

"My dad hits my mum, and my mum doesn't seem to care about me."

5 to 10 years

Developing: logic · copying adults · ideas of male and female roles · learning good and bad · relationships with peers

"My parents shout at each other, so I should shout too."

"Dad and step-dad are violent. That's what it means to be a man."

"Shouting and hitting are good. It's what my parents do."

"I will have relationships like the ones I have with my parents."

Also known as attachment theory.



The brain has two principles

It looks for patterns, and it is built to survive. For Sam, the threat might not be a snarling dog. It might be a relationship.



1

Pattern seeking

The brain sorts the world into familiar and unfamiliar. When we try to comfort Sam, the brain may read it as a threat, because relationships in the past were threatening.

2

Survival orientated

When we are scared, the brain goes into survival mode. Walter Cannon described fight or flight in 1915. We now talk about five responses.

Fight | **Flight** | **Freeze** | **Flop** | **Fawn**

When we see a red flag

Adults: likely logical and regulated	Children: likely emotive and unregulated
Call a friend	Become triggered
Communicate boundaries	Push people away
Sit with the emotion	Panic

"Connections on the outside build connections on the inside."

Dr Becky Bailey

What you see, and what it might be

These are not choices. They are a body trying to stay safe. Knowing which one you are seeing helps you respond to the fear, not just the behaviour.



Learn | On your own

Response	What you might see	What it might be	What can help
Fight	Shouting, arguing, lashing out.	Fear, dressed as anger.	Calm first. Lower your voice. Talk later.
Flight	Walking out, running off, staying out.	Leaving before being let down.	Don't chase into conflict. Say where you will be.
Freeze	Going quiet or blank.	Overwhelmed, can't find words.	Stop the questions. Sit alongside.
Flop	"Whatever", shutting down, sleeping.	Armour against rejection.	Don't read it as disrespect. Stay warm.
Fawn	Pleasing, agreeing, "I'm fine".	Keeping adults happy to stay safe.	Notice the "fine". Make it safe to say no.

Your turn: decode one behaviour

What I see	What it might be	What I will try

Done when. You have one guess about what sits underneath, and one thing to try.

Back to practice. Try it this week. Notice what changes, even a little.

"Might" matters. These are guesses to test, not a diagnosis, and they never cancel out a consequence.

Two timetables

Sam lives on two timetables at once: school's and children's social care's. Only the headteacher and the designated teacher know Sam is in care. When the two clash, Sam pays.



What school sees	What social care was doing
Missed a lesson. Absconding?	Seeing their social worker, or in a review meeting.
No PE kit. Detention.	Lost in an emergency move to a new foster home.
Late on Monday. Another sanction.	Trying to call a social worker who starts at 9, after school has started.
Homework not done.	

Two common approaches. Where is your natural position?

Behaviourist — **Nurturist**

Sanction and reward · routine · discipline

Behaviour is communication · compassion · relationships

Mark where you sit on the line. It is a spectrum, not a side.

Sam says: "I don't want anyone to know I am in care."

Why do you think Sam doesn't want people to know? What do you do?

Your two timetables planner

Map one week for your young person. School in one colour, social care in another: visits, reviews, family time, therapy, PEP meetings. Then look for the clashes.



On your own | With your team

Why. So the adults around a young person see the whole week, not just their half of it.

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Weekend

Where do the two timetables clash?

Who needs to know, and who will tell them?

Who's who around a young person in care at school

Designated teacher. Every school has one for children in care.

Virtual school head. Champions the education of children in care across the council.

Social worker. The young person's own social worker.

Supervising social worker. Supports foster carers.

Independent reviewing officer. Chairs the young person's reviews.

PEP. The personal education plan, reviewed every term.



3 Action

Four tools you can use this week. Then back to Jay.

In this part

Tool 1: Just say yes	On your own	Page 19
Tool 2: Spot, Soothe, Shift, and practice	Learn	Page 20
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Tool 4: Separating Reason from Behaviour, Jay, and practice	Learn	Page 23

Where you are

Story | **Theory** | **Action** You are here | **Keep**

Tool 1: Just say yes

If we agree the words in Sam's profile are wrong, changing how we record is not enough. Sam is being turned away today. So until the words change, we ignore them.



On your own | With your team

1

Ignore what is written

Meet the young person, not the file. The words were written on someone else's worst day.

2

End the cycle of rejection

Every no confirms what a young person already believes about themselves.

3

Just say yes

To the place, the school, the home. Then get to know them.

Before you say no to a young person, ask yourself

- [ ] Have I met them, or only read about them?
- [ ] Which of the five biases might be doing my thinking?
- [ ] Do I know their story, or only their profile?
- [ ] What would need to be true for me to say yes?
- [ ] If I say no, who will say yes?

Your turn: a time you, or your service, said no. What would saying yes have taken?



Done when. You can name what a yes would have needed.

Back to practice. Next time a referral lands, meet before you decide, wherever you can.

Tool 2: Spot, Soothe, Shift

Being a safe adult, to help young people learn to trust. Spot and Soothe always come first. Then stop and decide which way to go.



Learn

Spot

Always first

Notice and name the feeling. Let them finish. Say back what you heard and tell them the feeling makes sense.

"It makes sense you feel this way. That's a lot to deal with."

Soothe

Always second

Help them feel understood and safe. Slow down, lower your voice, leave silences. Not: "At least..."

"I'm here. We can talk now, or I can find you later."

Then stop and decide

1. Could they, or another child, be at risk of harm? 2. Are they calm, heard, and ready to hear a strength?

Signpost Q1: yes, or not sure	A disclosure is never reframed or shifted. Be honest you can't keep it secret. Tell your safeguarding lead straight away.	"I can't keep this just between us. I need to tell someone whose job is to help keep you safe."
Stay with Soothe Q2: not yet, or a loss	The default. Grief, loss and unfairness are real. Some hurts should not be reframed.	"That's really unfair. I'm sorry it's happened."
Shift Q2: yes	Only when ready. Ask first, name one real strength, then pause. Pushed back? Go back to Spot.	**"Can I tell you something I've noticed about you?"**

Spot, Soothe, Shift was developed by The Care Leaders. It was first called Recognise, Reassure, Reframe. A practice framework: evidence-informed, not trial-tested.

Practise Spot, Soothe, Shift

Three composite moments. For each one, write what you spot, how you would soothe, and which way you would go next.



On your own | With your team

What good looks like

Kai, 12, after a cancelled family visit: "Nobody ever turns up for me." **Spot:** "You were really looking forward to seeing her." **Soothe:** "I'm sorry. I'm here." **Then:** it's a loss, so stay with Soothe today. Shift another day.

Mia, 13 · after family time

"She doesn't even care about me."

What I spot	How I soothe	Signpost, stay, or shift?

Tyler, 15 · at school

"There's no point. I'll be moved again anyway."

What I spot	How I soothe	Signpost, stay, or shift?

Ash, 11 · at bedtime

"You'll get rid of me like the others did."

What I spot	How I soothe	Signpost, stay, or shift?

Done when. You have chosen a way on for each one, and can say why.

Back to practice. Use Spot and Soothe the next time a young person tells you something hard.

Tool 3: Challenging stigma

When a young person says they don't want people to know they have a social worker, it is usually because they expect to be judged. If we don't challenge that, we quietly agree they will be.



On your own

1. **Tell them they will not be judged**
   And if they ever feel they are, they come to you.
2. **Explore both scenarios**
   What it looks like if teachers do know, and if they don't.
3. **Involve them in the decision**
   Agree together what to say to teachers in either case.
4. **Don't take their first answer**
   Ask them to go away for a couple of days and think about it.
5. **Tell them you want to have their back**
   Whatever they decide.

Try saying

"Lots of young people feel like that. Can we think about what it would look like if your teachers knew, and if they didn't? You don't have to decide today."



Who knows about your young person's care now?

Which step would you find hardest, and why?

Done when. You know who knows, and what your young person wants.

Back to practice. Have the conversation, using the five steps, before the next term starts.

Tool 4: Separating Reason from Behaviour

Holding young people accountable in a way that gives them ownership to change. Respond to the reason first, then the behaviour. Both matter. Adapted from emotion coaching.



Learn

Above the line: the behaviour, what you see

Later, calm and in private

The behaviour

Shouting, walking out, slamming a door, refusing. You see it first. You don't respond to it first.

3 Highlight the behaviour

"Feeling this way is OK. Behaving that way isn't."

4 Give ownership

"What can we do differently next time?"

Below the line: the reason, what you can't see

In the moment

1 Recognise the reason

"I can see something's not right for you today."

2 Offer support

"You don't have to talk now. I'll check in later."

What might be under the line

Tired, hungry, embarrassed, worried about home, struggling with a friend. You may never know. That's fine. The stages still work.



If the reason is a safety concern, stop at stage 2. Follow your safeguarding procedures and speak to your safeguarding lead straight away.

Avoid three things

- **Personalising the system**
- **Excusing behaviour**
- **Worrying you'll get it wrong**

Back to Jay

When a young person says something personal that stops you in your tracks, your anger drops and the behaviour slips past. This is called alarm and disarm. Here is how Mr Hughes could have used Tool 4.



In the room

What good looks like

1. "Thanks for telling me. I wasn't aware."
2. "I want you to know you can talk to me about this, or to our designated teacher. We want to make sure you have support."
3. "Lighters still aren't allowed in school."
4. "I'll keep it in my drawer. Come and see me at the end of the day and you can have it back, and we'll agree it stays at home."

Your turn: look back at what you wrote on page 4. What would you change now?

Practise Tool 4

We are taught to deal with behaviour in two common ways: the behaviourist, and the nurturer. Both can go wrong. Rewrite each one using the four stages.



With your team | On your own

Escalation nation

Event: Timmy is late for school.

Miss Trunchball: "Why are you late?"

Timmy: "I don't know, miss."

Miss Trunchball: "How can you not know? Detention."

Timmy: "Whatever." "Nowt, miss. Chill out."

Rewrite it with the four stages

1

2

3

4

The "fine" line

Event: Dave forgets his homework.

Peter: "You didn't do your homework. Are you OK?"

Dave: "I'm fine." Peter: "Are you sure?"

Peter: "You don't seem fine. You can speak to me."

Dave: "I'm fine!" Peter: "OK, sorry."

Rewrite it with the four stages

1

2

3

4

On a hard day, are you more Trunchball or Peter? Where do you sit on the spectrum?

Back to practice. Run one scenario in your next team meeting or support group, in pairs.



4

Keep

The tools and pages to come back to, on your own and with your team.

In this part

Words that work	Tool to keep	Page 27
What builds trust	On your own	Page 28
Key learning and your commitment	On your own	Page 29
Cards, check-ins, team plan and reading	Tool to keep	Page 30

Where you are

Story	Theory	Action	**Keep** You are here

Words that work

Much of the language in care was written for systems, not young people. They hear it, and later they read it in their files. Start here, and add your own.



Tool to keep **With your team**

Instead of	A young person might hear	Try
Placement	This is temporary.	Home
Contact	I need permission to see my family.	Family time
LAC	I am a label.	Their name, or "a child in care"
Absconded	I am a criminal.	Left without telling us
Refused to engage	It is my fault.	Didn't want to talk yet
Kicked off	I am bad.	Was overwhelmed
Attention seeking	My needs are a nuisance.	Connection seeking
Respite	They need a break from me.	A sleepover, a short break
Placement breakdown	I broke it.	The move, or "it ended"
LAC review	A meeting about me, without me.	My meeting
Challenging	Something is wrong with me.	Needs the most support

The one word I will stop using from today

Words my young person prefers

Inspired by sector work on care language, including TACT's Language that Cares (2019). Ask the young person which words they prefer. Their answer wins.

What builds trust

For many young people in care, adults have removed them, moved them and decided their lives in meetings they weren't in. Distrust is based on evidence. Trust comes back through predictability, not persuasion.



On your own

Rate yourself with your young person: 1 rarely, 5 always

I do what I said, when I said I would.	1 2 3 4 5
I explain decisions before they land.	1 2 3 4 5
I tell them what I am writing or saying about them.	1 2 3 4 5
I repair after a hard conversation.	1 2 3 4 5
I keep the same face, the same time, the same place where I can.	1 2 3 4 5

My lowest score, and why

One thing I will do to move it up by one



Done when. You have one specific thing to do, with a date.

Back to practice. Rate yourself again in a month, on the check-in page.

We have a duty to break cycles

Three things to take with you, and one thing you will do this week.



Key learning

1. **The words written about a young person shape whether anyone says yes to them.**

2. **Behaviour that looks like defiance is often a survival response to past relationships.**

3. **A safe adult can hold a boundary and still keep the young person close.**

This week, with the young person I have in mind, I will

Quick reference cards

Cut along the dashes. Keep one on the fridge, one in your bag, one in your diary.



1 · Just say yes

Ignore what is written until it is right.

End the cycle of rejection.

Meet them before you decide.

2 · Spot, Soothe, Shift

Spot the feeling. **Soothe:** "I'm here."

Then decide: **Signpost** any disclosure, **stay** with a loss, **shift** only when ready.

3 · Challenging stigma

1 They will not be judged. 2 Explore both scenarios. 3 Decide together. 4 Don't take the first answer. 5 Have their back.

4 · Reason and behaviour

In the moment: 1 recognise the reason, 2 offer support.

Later, in private: 3 highlight the behaviour, 4 give ownership.

Five biases

Age · Gender · Anchor · Horns · Confirmation.

Ask: what would prove me wrong?

Five survival responses

Fight · Flight · Freeze · Flop · Fawn.

Respond to the fear, not just the behaviour.

Come back to this

Learning sticks when you return to it. Put three reminders in your diary now.



On your own

One week

Date:

Did you do your commitment? What happened? What did your young person notice?

One month

Date:

Which tool have you used most? Rate yourself on trust again: what moved?

Three months

Date:

Watch the recording again. What do you hear now that you missed the first time?

Notes



Run it with your team

Any page marked With your team works in supervision, a team meeting or a foster carer support group. The method is the same every time.



With your team

1 **Choose one page**

Pick one activity. Twenty minutes is enough.

2 **Everyone writes, in silence**

Each person does the Your turn part on their own, about their own young person, anonymised.

3 **Share one line each**

Each person reads out one line from what they wrote. No discussion yet.

4 **Agree one change**

The group agrees one thing it will do differently. Write it below.

5 **Check it next time**

Whoever leads asks about the change at the next meeting.

A four-session plan

Session	Page	Our change, and who checks
1	We inherit words and Words that work	
2	Rewrite a profile	
3	Practise Spot, Soothe, Shift	
4	Practise Tool 4	

Where the ideas come from

If you want to go deeper, these are the sources behind the theory in this keynote.



Learn

Bowlby, J. (1969) *Attachment and Loss, Volume 1: Attachment.*
Where attachment theory began.

Cannon, W. B. (1915) *Bodily Changes in Pain, Hunger, Fear and Rage.*
The first description of fight or flight.

Walker, P. (2013) *Complex PTSD: From Surviving to Thriving.*
Names the fawn response.

Bailey, B. *Conscious Discipline.*
The source of "connections on the outside build connections on the inside".

Gottman, J. (1997) *Raising an Emotionally Intelligent Child.*
The emotion coaching approach that Tool 4 adapts.

Greene, R. (2008) *Lost at School.*
Children do well if they can; behaviour signals a need.

TACT (2019) *Language that Cares.*
Changing the language of care, written with children in care.

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Watch it again

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